the expanded documentary has generated an explosion of independent filmmakers—Shaunak Sen, Nakul Singh Sawhney, Payal Kapadia, Prateek Vats and others—who scour the underbelly of the social order and produce dissent in an interrogatory, often ironic, mode." In this new phase "of the documentary as genre", she says, "it does not differentiate between the narrative and the anecdotal, the political and the hallucinatory".

Kapur's interest in the 'canon'—what we think of as

KAPUR IS DEEPLY INTERESTED IN THE **REVOLUTIONARY POTENTIAL OF CULTURAL ARTEFACTS**, AND THE POLITICS AND ECONOMICS OF ART PRODUCTION

a category of important art—surfaces throughout. Art from non-western countries has traditionally been excluded from the canon. "My position is that canons come into existence through institutional and ideological endorsement in contexts of (western/imperial) privilege; non-western art is then automatically considered derivative," she says. "The time for this is over. Canons are inverted, erased and substituted by artists within their own cultures. As often, and perhaps more unexpectedly, they incite a wager and produce linguistic paradoxes." ■

—Bhavya Dore

BOOKS ▼

DIVINE ARTISTRY

ASHOK VAJPEYI, A CLOSE FRIEND OF S.H. RAZA, DRAWS AN INTIMATE PORTRAIT OF THE ARTIST IN *CELEBRATION & PRAYER*



CELEBRATION & PRAYER: Life and Light in Raza's Art
By Ashok Vajpeyi
SPEAKING TIGER
₹599; 184 pages

If Raza rose from his grave and read the vast literature on his art, he would learn a lot about what he had never painted, not intended that to be the mission or message of his work! He was a quiet, wise man humbled by his own cosmic vision. A lot of irrelevance has been attributed to Raza's art while his internal *tapasya*—meditation—was tuned more towards a spiritual reverence to colours and forms. Ashok Vajpeyi's quiet little book scores some advantages: brevity, intimacy, and a poetic interpretation, which stays clear of art jargon. Raza would have been pleased, as his tale has been simply told. Nor does the octogenarian author overplay the proximity card to score points over other critics. Some incisive observations tell of this friendship, by suggestion. Vajpeyi's narrative flows with a seasoned effortlessness of a poet with a confident facility for words. As a good biographer, he simply holds out Raza as a shadow puppet where the skill of the puppeteer is evident. His protagonist was similar. Raza quietly transformed geometry into art in a very profound way. The author suggests how "Raza's own exploration of pure form as he sometimes called it, was influenced by his study of Cézanne, Mondrian and Vaserly, and thoughts of Kandinsky. Later, he got interested in the pure geometry, taken forward by Nicolas de Staël". Vajpeyi writes, "Susan Sontag once said, 'What good are one's roots, if one cannot take them around'." Raza took his roots around, rich in memory and resonances, and planted them in his art. He became the plant that grew vast branches, immortalising his colours into forever sunsets and sunrises—with the palette of the rainbow at the beck and call of the Master's innumerable geometries, evoking the 'aspect of eternity, rather than history'. ■

VAJPEYI EFFORTLESSLY HOLDS UP RAZA AS A SHADOW PUPPET, WITH THE SKILL OF THE PUPPETEER EVIDENT

—Aman Nath